

Information security starts with all of us

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News *Information security starts with all of us* has been updated.



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WaTech's Information Security Services (ISS) would like to remind employees about the importance of complying with agency policies regarding the use of personal devices for agency business.

The primary objective of the Information Security Program is to establish effective information security controls and practices that reduce cybersecurity-related risks to our agency—especially the use of personal equipment.

And the reason is very simple: The agency invests a lot of effort and time to ensure agency computers and mobile devices are secure and compliant. Using unapproved personal devices opens a hole in that security layer and could lead to malware, ransomware or exfiltration of sensitive data.

Given the modern-day risks posed by the exfiltration of potentially massive amounts of data at rapidly diminishing speeds, we can't afford to compromise our systems by connecting personal devices that aren't managed by our agency.

Consider these examples from history:

- Between 1969-70, it took Daniel Ellsberg about 10 months to photocopy approximately 7,000 pages of the Pentagon Papers before they were eventually released to the New York Times in 1971. (No judgement here; we're just using a well-known example from history for comparison purposes.) If you stacked 7,000 pages they would measure about 28 inches high (slightly higher than the roll-around filing cabinet under your desk).
- By contrast, during the Equifax data breach in 2017 hackers exfiltrated 143 million records over the course of 76 days. Assuming for the moment that one data record equals one page, if you stacked 143 million pages they would measure more than 9.5 miles high. Commercial jet traffic would literally be clipping the top of Equifax's data breach as they flew past.

And that's why the WaTech information security program is so adamant about ensuring we all follow these guidelines outlining the use of personal devices for agency business:

- Non-standard devices (such as personal printers, removable storage devices, USB drives) are not authorized. Exceptions may be considered based on strong business justification, documented risk and device supportability.
- Personal laptops, and workstations accessing government resources are not permitted.
- Personal mobile devices are not permitted to access government resources without documented approval from ISS. Exceptions are considered based on strong business justification, risk levels and device supportability. Users requesting use of personal devices must submit a request in ServiceNow for ISS review.

In the near future all WaTech employees should expect to acknowledge and agree to comply with the Access and Confidentiality Agreement, which states, "I understand that I am prohibited from: 11. Use of employee-owned computers, devices, or removable media for state business."

Remember: IT security starts with all of us.

